



to practise in hotels without mats. We also used to not have outdoor practice tracks. The biggest benefit was acquiring quality NYP players through the academy."

UP, retaining its core for PKL 10, welcomed new additions like Gurdeep, Kiran Magar, Nitin Panwar and the experienced Vijay Malik. Narwal opines, "Our team is fine. We have quality players on our side like Nitesh and Surrender. We also have Vijay this time but the team will only be called good if we perform when it matters."

Before the Bengaluru leg, UP found itself in troubled waters against the Bengaluru Bulls. Narwal, the standout performer for UP, orchestrated a remarkable comeback, amassing 13 points and reaching the milestone of 1600 career raid points along the way. Despite his extraordinary performance, UP suffered a narrow two-point defeat, leaving Narwal visibly frustrated.

"*Dukh toh hota hi hai bhai* (It hurts, brother)... Bengaluru had lost all four games before facing us, and we served the match to them on a

platter. It is painful," he says.

Discussing his on-field strategy, he says, "I never get angry at anyone. *Khair par gussa utarna bhi nhi chahiye....* (No one should vent their anger on someone). Nobody tries to wreck things on their own....mistakes happen, and you should calm down and explain to others so that they don't make the same mistakes. So, rather than intimidating someone, I believe in taking things slowly."

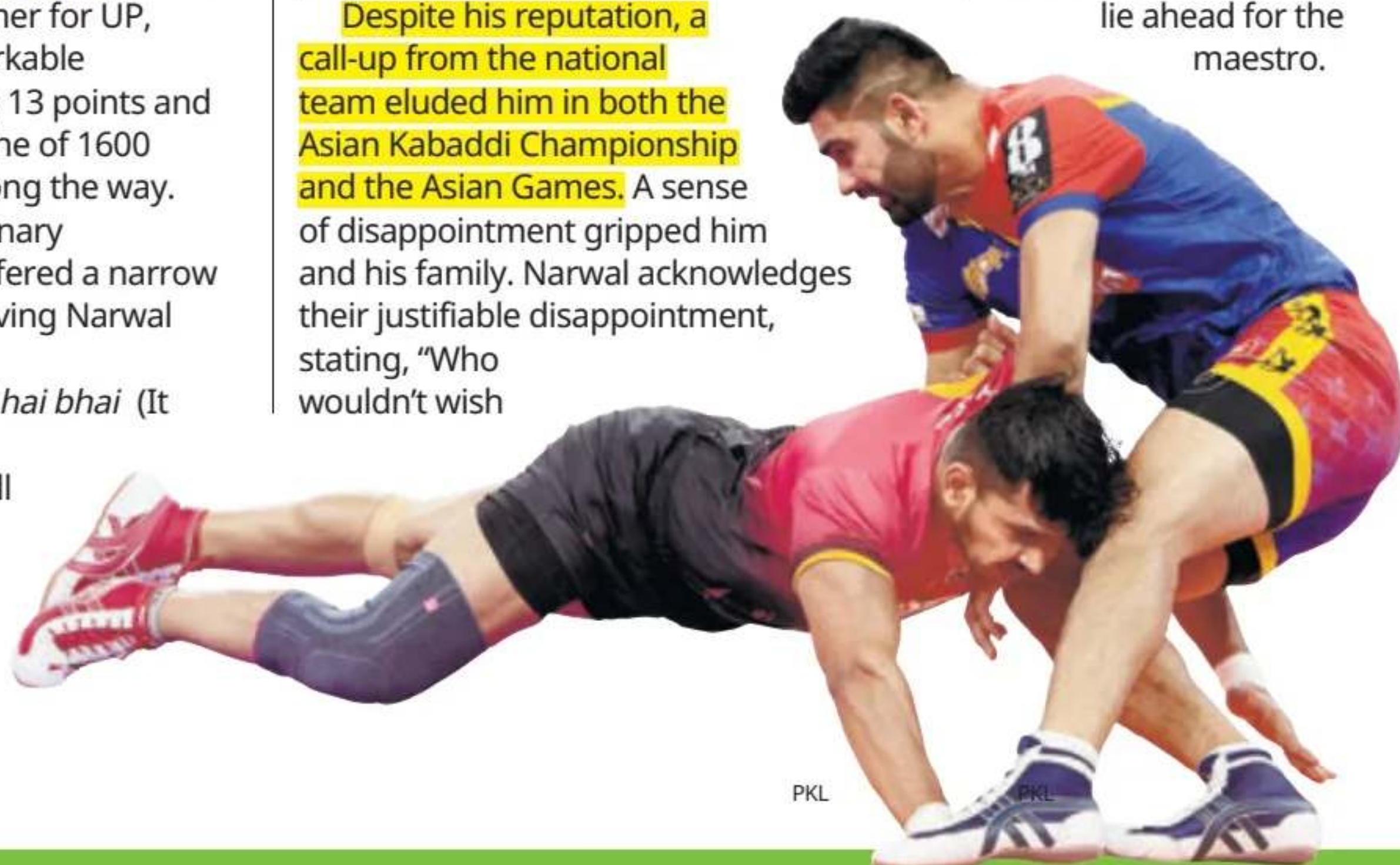
When a player of Narwal's stature enters the picture, pedigree follows. He will make you sweat and force you to fight for every point until the very end, which is what makes him the player he is.

Despite his reputation, a call-up from the national team eluded him in both the Asian Kabaddi Championship and the Asian Games. A sense of disappointment gripped him and his family. Narwal acknowledges their justifiable disappointment, stating, "Who wouldn't wish

Lone ranger: In the match largely dictated by the raiders of Bengaluru Bulls (in black), Pardeep (centre) orchestrated a remarkable comeback, amassing 13 points and reaching 1600 career raid points. PKL

for their son to excel? They were disheartened. It took them a while, but they came to understand that playing for India was not destined for me at that time."

With aspirations of 1800 raid points and a trophy for UP, Narwal's vision board is ambitious. However, with the once-invincible raider looking more human as seasons go by, one wonders what uncertainties lie ahead for the maestro.



PKL